violence, Kamran was finally captured in 1553 by a Gakkhar chieftain and sent to Humayun.

That Humayun was extremely conflicted over Kamran's fate is evident in Gulbadan's account of the episode. He gathered all the Mughal nobility and the soldiers together and asked them for their advice. 'Brotherly custom has nothing to do with ruling and reigning,' he was told. 'If you wish to act as a brother, abandon the throne.' In the end, it was decided to blind Kamran, effectively ending his challenge to rule. 'Though my head inclines to your words, my heart does not,' grieved Humayun, who had tried to reason with Kamran for many years. Finally the order to blind Kamran was given but the servants baulked, and 'disputed among themselves who was to perform the cruel act'. But the deed was done, at last, and Kamran was led back to his own camp where the water-bearer Jauhar, 'seeing the prince in such pain and distress, could no longer remain with him'. Kamran was sent to Mecca where he died four years later while his young son, Abu'l Qasim, was kept a prisoner.

In Kabul, meanwhile, a son was born to Humayun's new wife, Mah-chuchak Begum, and he was given the name Muhammad Hakim*. A few months later Akbar was given a new ataliq, Munim Khan, a Chaghatai nobleman who had been in Humayun's service since the time of his peregrinations in Sind. This was an honour which Munim Khan celebrated with a great banquet and the distribution of gifts. By 1554 Humayun was the last of the Timurid mirzas still able to stake a claim to the empire founded in Hindustan with such blistering haste by Babur. Sher Shah Sur had died in 1545 and when Humayun heard of the death of his son, Islam Shah, in November 1554, he must have felt that the stars, cold and uncaring, were at last turning favourable to him.

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*In Punjab, present-day Pakistan.

*Gulbadan's husband.

*Henceforth known as Mirza Hakim.